



◀ PROCESSOR:
INTEL CORE i7-2600K
Price: ₹17,500



Intel Processors

Intel introduced the Sandy Bridge line up of processors early in the year. It came with innovative features such as Quick Sync video, integrated graphics on the same 32-nm die as the processor and advanced vector extensions capable of handling 256-bit floating point executions, among other things.

Zero1 Winner

Intel Core i7-2600K

Throughout the year, this processor ruled the roost, so much so that even the 8-core Bulldozer from AMD couldn't shake it off the top. It performed very well in all the benchmarks. We were particularly impressed with the hardware acceleration due to the Quick Sync technology. Overclocking the processor is also quite easy.

Worthy Mention

Intel Core i5-2500K

This is the only other Sandy Bridge processor we got from Intel in the entire year. Clocked at just 100 MHz lower than the 2600K, the 2500K is a great processor as its performance difference from 2600K is only around 10-15 per cent.

Intel Core i7-3960X

The Sandy Bridge E series processor arrived in our labs very late. It's being claimed worldwide as the fastest processor on the planet right now. Had it come to us earlier we would have run it through its paces and it might have even won the award. It replaces the older generation Core i7-980X. It doesn't have integrated graphics, does not or Intel SRT, it can support upto four dual-channel memory slots.



Intel Core
i5-2500K
Price: ₹11,700



ASRock Z68
Extreme7 Gen3
Price: ₹18,999

Motherboards

At the start of the year there were two chipsets: H67 – which didn't allow overclocking but allowed you to use integrated graphics and P67 – which allowed overclocking but you had to let go of integrated graphics. The answer to the dilemma was solved by the Z68 chipset. Not only did it allow you to use the integrated graphics (provided boards had display ports) as well as overclock the board. Through a new feature called Intel Smart Response Technology you can set an SSD in RAID with your hard drive, additionally you can use your SSD as a cache memory for your hard drive, improving application loading times of the most frequently used apps.

Zero1 Winner

ASUS ROG Maximus IV Extreme Z

Belonging to the Republic of Gamers series, this board has top-notch build quality, eight connectors on board to ensure sufficient cooling, etc. It houses an NVIDIA NF200 chip which controls the second and fourth PCIe x16 slot allowing you to run two graphics cards in SLI at x16/x16 speeds. It helps in 3-way SLI as well. Onboard ROG features are quite exhaustive and give you many options to overclock and tweak the system via relevant utilities. It also has the best UEFI BIOS implementation among competing brands.

Worthy Mention

ASRock Z68 Extreme7 Gen3

It looks quite impressive with angular designs on the heat sinks, there are as many as 10 SATA ports on the board. It comes with a UEFI BIOS as well as the NVIDIA NF200 chip for 3-way SLI. Pricing is quite decent for the kind of features on offer.



▲ MOTHERBOARD:
ASUS MAXIMUS IV EXTREME Z
Price: ₹26,220